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Democracy Dies in Darkness

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Steadfast honesty a liability for Carter

Pendant for the truth didn't always play well for American public

BY MARC FISHER

During the four years of Jimmy Carter's presidency, his approval rating plummeted from 75 percent to 28 percent, according to the Gallup Poll, yet most Americans still considered him an honest and decent man.

During the 43 years of Carter's golden post-presidency, that reputation for honesty and decency elicited mostly generous reviews from presidential scholars and full-hearted praise from Americans who'd turned sour on most of the chief executives who succeeded him.

But that same character trait that first lifted Carter to the White House as the smiling, soft-spoken truth-teller who could be an antidote to the cynicism and corruption of Richard M. Nixon turned out to have a mixed legacy — leaving Carter honored for committing himself to rigorous honesty, yet criticized for a naivete (or disingenuousness) that made it harder for him to get things done and stay in office.

On the heels of Nixon's abuses and deceptions, which led to his resignation from office in 1974, Carter won the presidency in 1976 buoyed by a blast of goodwill. He was — as he reminded voters with his campaign slogan, “Why not the best?” — the rare candidate who promised he would never lie.

Announcing his presidential bid in December 1974, the Georgia governor told a crowd at the Atlanta Civic Center that as president, “I would not tell a lie; I would not mislead the American people. ... And I would not betray

SEE CARTER ON A4

Mall of the future is now a thing of the kitschy past

An underground mall full of mom-and-pop stores is in its last days

BY TEO ARMUS

The Tex-Mex restaurant had closed months ago. The camera store down the hall was moving online. Even the puppet shop — the one with the marionettes and googly-eyed Elmos in the window — was boarding up.

So two weeks before her own lease ran out, Elaine Demos could do little but pace inside her shoebox of a gift store and gaze out at what was left of the Crystal City Underground.

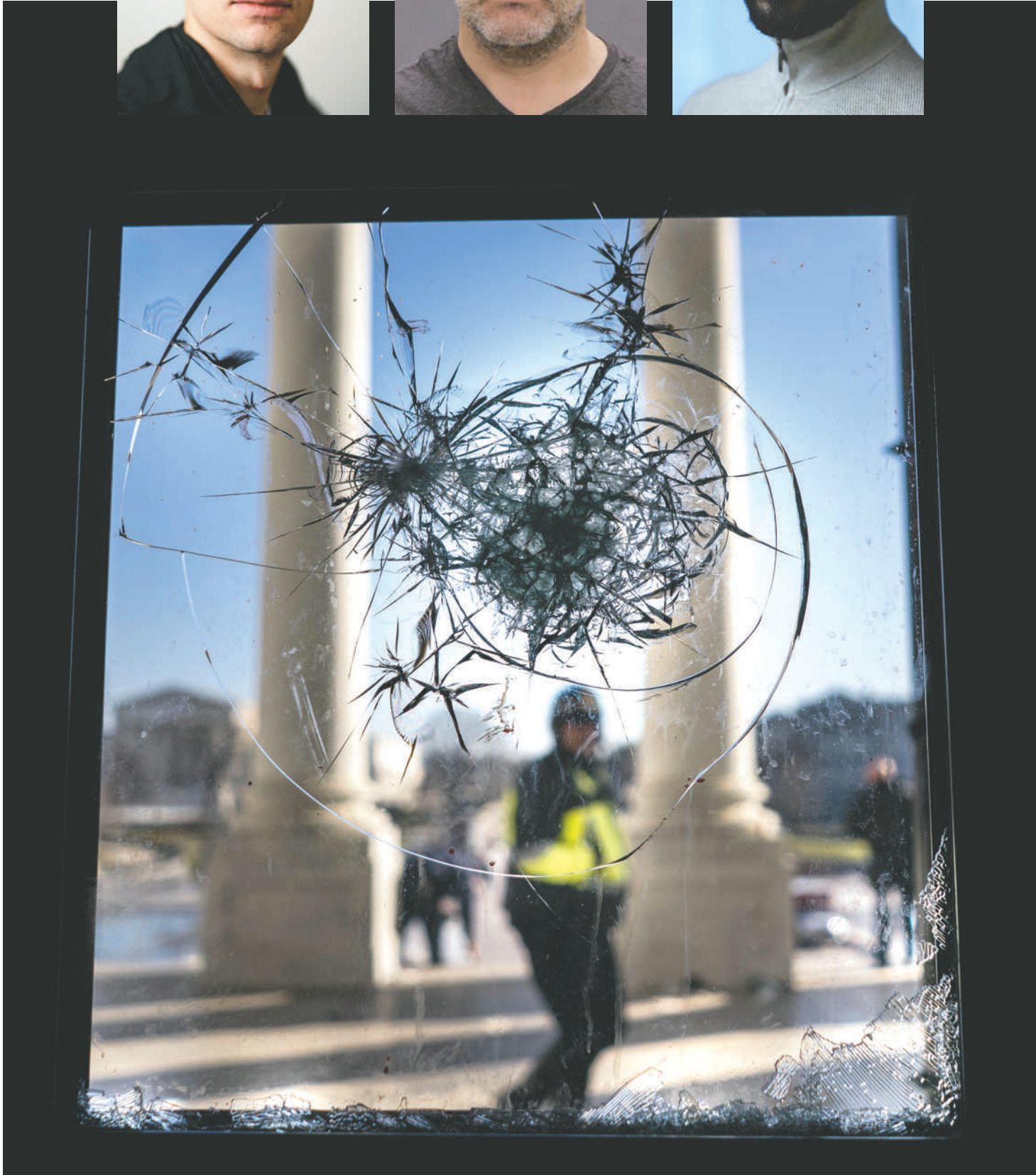
This suburban, nominally subterranean Northern Virginia shopping mall — a maze of kitschy mom-and-pop stores below office buildings and above a Metro station — had once seemed like something from the future. Weeks out from closing entirely, it had instead become a white-walled, climate-controlled purgatory.

“It used to be that everything you ever wanted was down here,” Demos said from behind the register. “Now, well, I just don't know what to do about what's left.”

Neither, it seems, did anyone else.

One longtime shopkeeper
SEE MALL ON A6

Nearly 1,600 people have been charged in the Jan. 6, 2021, attack on the Capitol. The president-elect has pledged to pardon many of them.



Their fate rests with Trump

FUQUAY-VARINA, N.C. — James Tate Grant couldn't bring himself to admit to his father that he joined the first attack on police at the U.S. Capitol on Jan. 6, 2021, opening the floodgates for a mob that halted the certification of the 2020 presidential election.

Harold Grant spent his career as a federal probation and parole officer and criminal justice instructor. He begged his son not to attend President Donald Trump's rally over what he falsely claimed was a stolen election. And after, when the elder Grant asked James whether he'd marched to the Capitol and gone inside, James lied and said he hadn't.

James Grant was eventually convicted of assaulting a police officer with a dangerous weapon, rioting and other charges. His law

This article is by Robert Klemko, Spencer S. Hsu, Tom Jackman, Sarah Cahlan, Clara Ence Morse and Hannah Dormido

school plans evaporated. He spent three years behind bars, then knocked on doors for Trump this fall after his release. He said he still believes the 2020 election might have been stolen. And he knows Trump has promised to pardon Jan. 6 defendants, which he wants more than anything.

His father, who said he'd never voted Republican for president until this fall, cast a ballot for Trump for the same reason. He said he doesn't believe his son — or Trump — about the previous election, but he thinks the Justice Department's prosecution of hundreds of defendants has been

overzealous.

“We know this was deterrence. We know exactly why it was done. But the human cost — it's just ridiculous,” Harold Grant said. In his son's mind, he added: “If he gets the pardon, it's validation. His only hope for any kind of reclamation, for his character and himself, is Donald Trump.”

The president-elect has pledged to pardon many Jan. 6 defendants during his first hour in office on Jan. 20, wiping away their punishment with the stroke of a pen and erasing much of the legal system's effort to address an unprecedented assault on the seat of American democracy. Two-thirds of Americans oppose pardons for people convicted of crimes in the riot, according to a

SEE DEFENDANTS ON A8

TOP: From left, convicted defendants James Tate Grant, Dominic Pezzola and Micaiah Joseph. ABOVE: A broken glass pane in a Capitol Rotunda door on the day after the attack.

MATT RAMEY FOR THE WASHINGTON POST, FBI/AP, MATT MCCLAIN/THE WASHINGTON POST, MELINA MARA/THE WASHINGTON POST

AI leap requires intimate access

COMPANIES PITCH ARTIFICIAL AGENTS

Experts warn tool poses security, privacy issues

BY GERRIT DE VYNCK

SAN FRANCISCO — Tech companies are racing to upgrade chatbots like ChatGPT not only to offer answers, but also to take control of a computer to take action on a person's behalf.

Experts in artificial intelligence and cybersecurity warn the technology will require people to expose much more of their digital lives to corporations, potentially bringing new privacy and security problems.

In recent weeks, executives from leading AI companies including Google, Microsoft, Anthropic and OpenAI have all predicted that a new generation of digital helpers termed “AI agents” will completely change how people interact with computers.

They claim the technology, set to be a major focus of the industry in 2025, will initially automate mundane tasks like online shopping or data entry and eventually tackle complex work that can take humans hours.

“This will be a very significant change to the way the world works in a short period of time,” OpenAI CEO Sam Altman said at a company event in October. “People will ask an agent to do something for them that would have taken a month, and it will finish in an hour.”

OpenAI has said agents will benefit from its recent work on

SEE AI ON A16

How Asian nations join to deport, jail dissidents

BY SHIBANI MAHTANI

PHNOM PENH, CAMBODIA — In January of last year, the Cambodian government brought the full diplomatic weight of the state down on a seemingly slight target: a 36-year-old maid working for a middle-class family just outside Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia.

Nuon Toeun was neither an activist nor an opposition leader. She spent her days cleaning her employer's home. She did, however, have an active social media presence on TikTok and Facebook, where she “expressed ... rage,” she said, at Cambodia's elite, including its former authoritarian leader, Hun Sen, and his son, Hun Manet, the current prime minister.

The Cambodian government issued a warrant for Toeun's arrest on Jan. 18, a few weeks after she posted a video saying Hun Sen was “dancing very happily” despite the “mountain of sadness” faced by the Cambodian people: poverty, land grabs and the targeting of opposition figures. Cambodia notified Malaysian authorities of the warrant, alleging she had insulted state institutions in violation of a six-year-old law that critics say has been used liberally against perceived opponents of the government.

SEE CAMBODIA ON A12

IN THE NEWS

Off to the playoffs The Commanders beat the Cowboys with a late touchdown to win their season finale and advance to a first-round postseason matchup with the Buccaneers. **D1**
Trump's deportation plan Fear runs through a Mexican town linked to California, Oregon and Illinois by the flow of remittances. **A10**

THE NATION
An orca whose grief stunned the world is mourning the loss of another calf. **A2**
The FBI released more information about the attack in New Orleans on New Year's Day. **A3**

THE WORLD
South Koreans have taken up U.S. flags and the slogan “Stop the Steal” in their own political battle. **A11**
Israel and Hezbollah traded threats as the end of a ceasefire neared. **A12**

THE ECONOMY
At Amazon, the annual holiday crush known internally as “peak” features swag, prizes — and mandatory overtime. **A13**

THE REGION
The attack on the U.S. Capitol still stirs anger and sadness among many working or living on Capitol Hill. **B1**

George Mason University held an opening event for its \$254-million Fuse tech hub, designed to bring together academic labs and industry leaders. **B1**
Initial renderings of the new D.C. jail evoke healing, some say, while critics see an unforgiving harshness. **B1**

STYLE
Twenty-five simple and affordable ways to improve your style in 2025. **C1**
A jury will decide whether CNN defamed a security contractor who claims it falsely accused him of taking advantage of Afghans during the 2021 U.S. withdrawal. **C1**

BUSINESS NEWS.....A13
COMICS.....C5
OBITUARIES.....B4
OPINION PAGES.....A14
TELEVISION.....C4
WORLD NEWS.....A10

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